

Teams that planned around all-rounders in the previous cycle were at a disadvantage when the rule was introduced midway. That wasn't ideal.

Being an all-rounder is one of the great challenges of T20 cricket. You're involved in all three aspects of the game, and that should be encouraged. Bowlers know they'll be targeted, but that's what makes the role exciting.

I would love to see the rule scrapped. I actually thought it would be this year — but clearly, it's not *(smiles)*.

The Impact Player rule isn't used in international cricket or some franchise leagues. How challenging is it for an all-rounder to adapt in the IPL?

I don't overthink it. I prepare as if I'm going to bowl or bat, and when the opportunity comes—or doesn't—that's just part of professional sport.

That's what makes these competitions great. No complaints — you get ready, take responsibility whether things go well or not, and look to improve in the next game.

It's the same challenge everywhere. But of course, I'd love to know in advance and be thrown into the contest. That's what I enjoy most about cricket.

With 300-plus scores becoming a real possibility in T20 cricket, has the format tilted too much in favour of batters? Will the new ball-change rule help bowlers?

The decision to change the ball midway through the second innings is a great move. Dew plays a big role, and this should help level the contest, making teams less reliant on the toss.

High scores are exciting, but they also highlight the quality of bowlers. The best, like (Jasprit) Bumrah, stand out because they execute their skills consistently, even on good batting tracks.

Last season's IPL saw unusually high scores compared to other leagues. With the T20 World Cup in India approaching, we can expect

another high-scoring tournament — which, for fans at home, makes for great entertainment.

Punjab Kings has gone 17 seasons without a title. What's the team's realistic target this year?

We've just come together, so those discussions will evolve. But with a new cycle, new coach, and



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new players—many of whom have worked together before—it feels like a fresh start. There's no baggage from past seasons. From the outside, history might be a talking point, but within the team, we see this as a new chapter.

With Rick and Shreyas leading, and a strong Australian contingent, we have the chance to build something special over the next three years. The first year of a cycle is always the most exciting—it sets the foundation for sustained success.

The squad has a good mix of youth and experience. As a senior player, what are your thoughts on the uncapped Indian players?

There's real talent in our squad, making selection a tough challenge. Right now, it feels like 18-20 players could make the XI, which is a great problem to have.

For the younger players, the message is simple — play freely and back yourselves. They're here for a reason, and this is their opportunity to shine.

The balance of youth and experience benefits everyone. The youngsters bring energy, while the experienced players provide guidance in pressure situations.

You've spoken highly of Ponting. Is he one of the toughest coaches you've worked with?

I've worked with Rick a lot, and I wouldn't call him a tough taskmaster, but he sets high standards. He values preparation, work ethic, and attitude. If you get those right, he's your biggest supporter.

One of his strengths is his approach to communication. He has a filter — before speaking, he considers whether his words will help you improve or lift your spirits. If they won't, he holds back. That makes him an excellent teacher and mentor.

Rick's infectious attitude and winning mindset align with mine. I love hard work, discipline, and playing to win, which is why we work so well together.